

PRIVATE CREDIT MONITOR

The longer-term view

- Developments in private credit have been closely watched by a wide range of market participants, with attention largely focused on a specific structure of business development companies (BDCs). While these retail-focused products have grown in recent years, they represent a relatively small portion of the private credit universe compared to institutional capital.
- For participants in the broader corporate credit markets, a key consideration is whether private credit's role in the financing ecosystem has changed as a result of recent events. We believe it remains intact and expect to see expanded deployment opportunities over the long-term, especially if dislocations emerge in the syndicated financing channels.
- The size of the private credit market is not outsized relative to other financing channels such as private equity, bank lending, and syndicated bonds and loans. We see scope for further expansion, as the opportunity set to finance privately held firms is significant. Additionally, the syndicated debt markets are serving ever larger borrowers, as illustrated by growth in average deal sizes.
- As experienced private credit managers have captured a greater share of fundraising, 'jumbo' (\$1 billion or larger) private credit loans have become more frequent. This has allowed private credit to further expand its addressable market of borrowers, serving larger firms which may have historically accessed syndicated credit markets. This has resulted in greater fluidity across the two financing channels and a 'financing continuum' between public and private markets.
- The most recent fundamental data (through year-end 2025) points to generally resilient and range-bound (vs. the last several quarters) metrics. The growth backdrop is one of the key signposts to watch, in our view, as a 'solid enough' macroeconomic backdrop is likely to validate the low realized losses seen in the asset class so far. And while many market participants remain focused on software exposure, as we highlight, the private credit industry is not isolated in that (larger) sector weighting.

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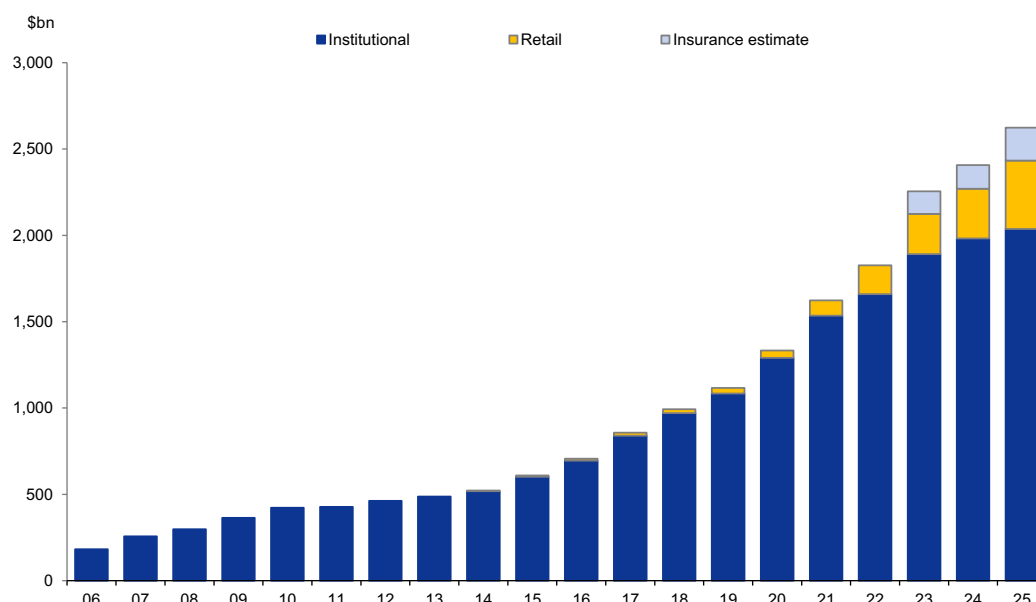
Private credit's established role in the financing markets

Developments in private credit have been closely watched by a wide range of market participants, with attention largely focused on a specific structure of business development companies (BDCs). These so-called 'non-traded' or 'evergreen' BDCs are vehicles used primarily by high net worth retail investors to gain access to private credit. They typically offer lower minimum investment denominations, the ability to become invested quickly (as opposed to waiting for a 'capital call'), and very modest amounts of liquidity (generally 5% of NAV, per quarter). These characteristics stand in sharp contrast to the larger fund sizes and 'locked up' capital which are representative of institutional private credit 'drawdown' funds.

Exhibit 1 tracks global private credit AUM by channel, using the 'traditional' definition of the asset class which most closely aligns to the 'direct lending' strategy (i.e., directly negotiated lending to middle market companies). It excludes other large and adjacent private credit strategies, such as those focused on private asset-based financing, for example. As this exhibit illustrates, the retail investor base represents a relatively small (albeit fast-growing) portion of the private credit universe compared to institutional capital.

Exhibit 1: The bulk of private credit AUM is held by institutional investors

Global private credit AUM by channel



Note: Institutional amounts are as of June 30, 2025, and the Insurance and Retail figures are as of December 31, 2025. This exhibit is focused on the 'traditional' definition of private credit and excludes strategies such as private asset-based finance.

Source: PitchBook LCD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Headline volatility surrounding the redemption activity in retail BDC-related segments of private credit may persist in the near term and has been well covered by our [colleagues](#) in equity research. For participants in the broader corporate credit markets, however, there is another important (and less discussed, in our view) angle to consider: whether private credit's role in the financing ecosystem has changed as a result of recent developments. We believe it remains intact and expect to see expanded deployment

opportunities over the long term, especially if the growth backdrop or sector-specific developments generate dislocations in the syndicated financing channels.

In this *Private Credit Monitor*, we frame the financing opportunity set around private credit. We also unpack the structural shifts which have expanded private credit's addressable market of borrowers over the past several years. Finally, we provide some context on the long-term historical trends around realized losses and returns for the asset class and take stock of signals from the most recent fundamental data (which generally remain resilient and consistent with the last several quarters).

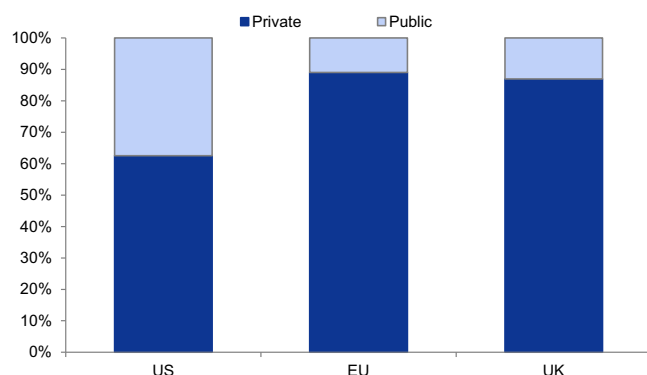
Framing the addressable market of private firms

The opportunity set to finance privately held firms is significant. As shown in Exhibit 2, 63% of firms in the US with \$100 million or more in annual revenue are private, and the shares of private firms in the EU and UK are even larger.

This collection of private firms across all three regions represents nearly \$12 trillion in aggregate annual revenue, per S&P Capital IQ estimates (Exhibit 3). For comparison, the annual revenue generated by the public company cohort totaled \$33 trillion for the most recent 12-month period.

Exhibit 2: The majority of firms in the US, EU and UK are private

Distribution (by count) of public and private firms in the US, EU and UK

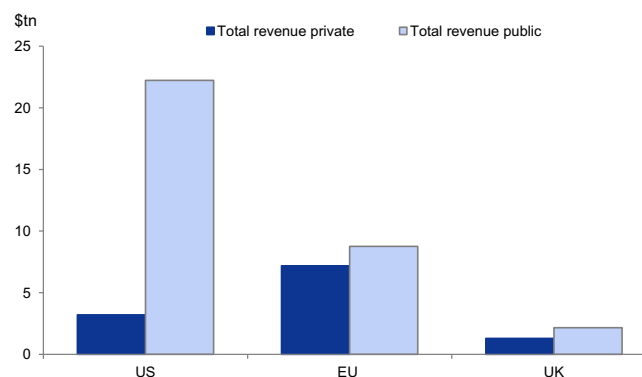


Note: Captures all public and private companies with \$100 million or more in annual revenue for each region. As of April 8, 2026.

Source: S&P Capital IQ, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: Annual revenue generated from private firms totals nearly \$12 trillion

Aggregate last twelve months (LTM) revenue for public and private companies in the US, EU and UK



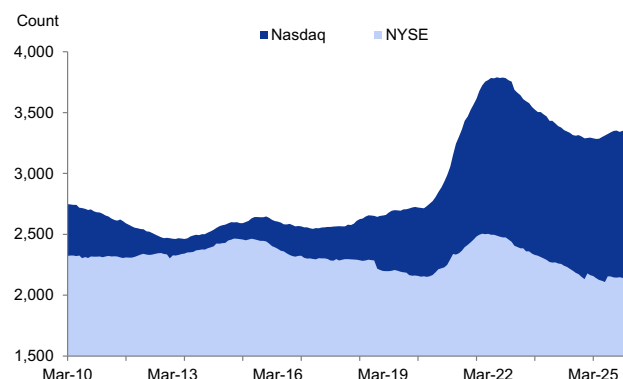
Note: Captures all public and private companies with \$100 million or more in annual revenue for each region. S&P Capital IQ estimates revenues for private firms. As of April 8, 2026.

Source: S&P Capital IQ, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Larger deal sizes in syndicated markets

Beyond the large absolute *quantity* of privately held firms, the 'barriers to entry' in the syndicated leveraged finance markets have also moved higher over the past several years as companies stay private for longer (Exhibit 4). This can be seen in the growing average new issue deal sizes in the USD high yield (HY) and broadly syndicated leveraged loan markets (Exhibit 5).

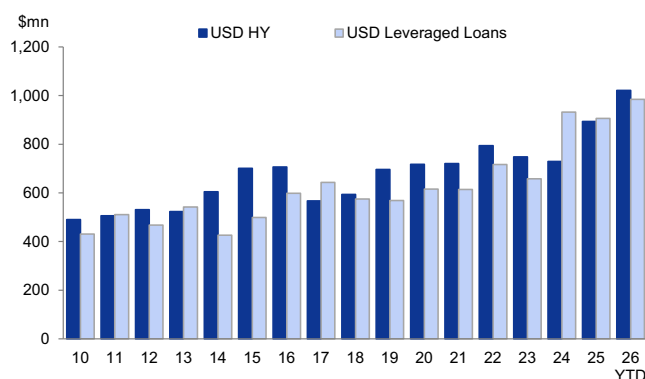
Exhibit 4: The number of publicly listed companies in the US has moderated from the post-pandemic peak
Number of listed companies on the NYSE and NASDAQ US stock exchanges



Note: As of February 2026 (most recent as of April 3, 2026).

Source: World Federation of Exchanges, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 5: Average deal sizes have increased in the syndicated leveraged finance market
Average deal sizes for new issues in the USD HY and leveraged loan markets



Note: As of April 3, 2026.

Source: Dealogic (ION Analytics), Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Using the USD HY bond market as an example, the average deal size from 2022 to 2025 was \$791 million. This is the size of *one debt deal—not an entire debt capital structure*. For a middle market firm seeking only a modest amount of debt financing, the syndicated debt markets may not be the most appropriate channel, as issuing a bond or loan which is barely index-eligible and ‘poorly held’ is often not in the best interest of the issuer or the investor. Over the past several years, private credit solutions have helped fill this ‘financing void’ for middle market companies—and we expect this pattern to remain in place, especially given the size of firms which now dominate the syndicated credit markets.

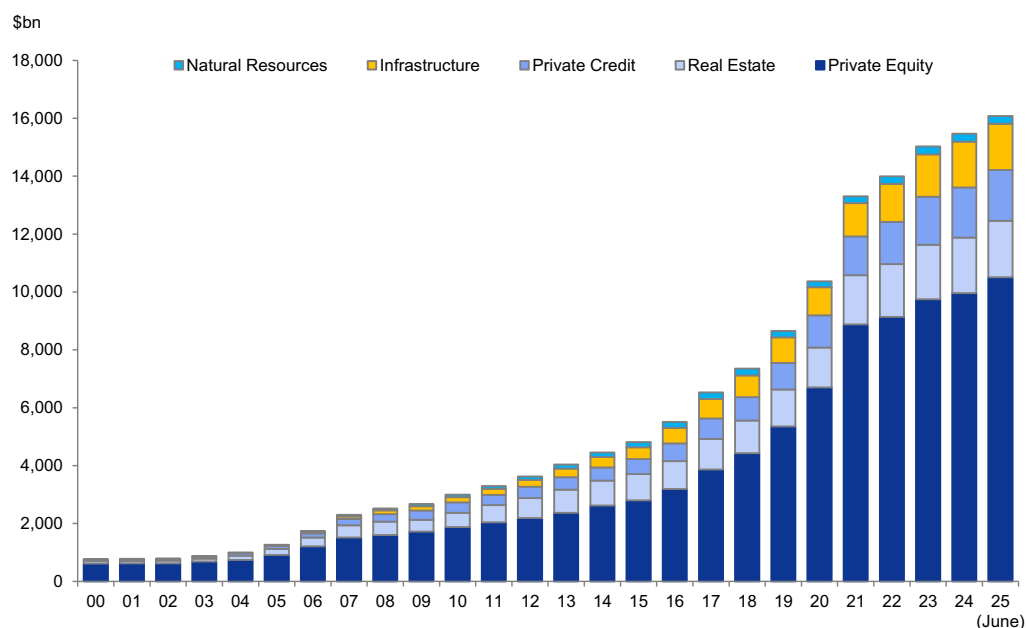
Sizing the private credit market (and related financing)

Providing some context on the growth of the private credit market, as well as its size relative to other financing channels, illustrates scope for further expansion, in our view. For purposes of this exercise, we again focus on the ‘traditional’ definition of private credit, which most closely aligns to directly negotiated financing to middle-market sized firms. The key takeaway, in our view, is that the size of private credit is still modest when compared to other alternative asset classes such as private equity as well as vs. portions of the bank lending and syndicated credit markets.

Exhibit 6 frames the global private credit market (using Preqin’s universe, which does not capture BDCs) relative to other alternative asset markets such as private equity. The size differentials are meaningful: at \$10.5 trillion in global AUM, private equity is 6x the size of the global private credit market.

Exhibit 6: The size of the private credit market is modest in comparison to private equity

Global private markets assets under management



Note: To avoid double counting of available capital and unrealized value, fund of funds and secondaries are excluded. As of June 2025 (most recent as of April 7, 2026, due to reporting lags).

Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

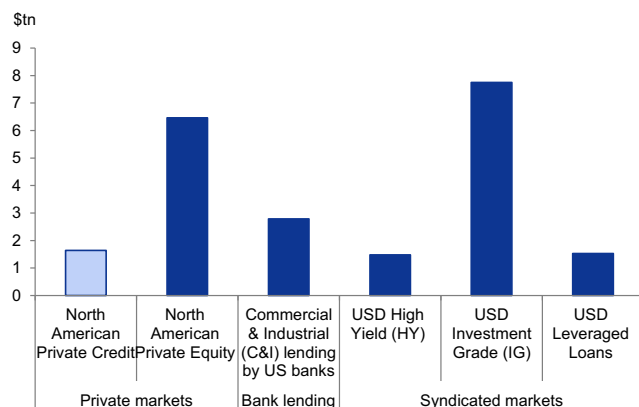
Exhibit 7 focuses on North America and widens the comparison to include the bank lending and syndicated markets. We also add the \$549 billion BDC universe tracked by Cliffwater to the North American private credit figures (as BDCs are a US-focused vehicle). Here too, we find a similar pattern: the size of North American private credit is very modest relative to North American private equity, smaller than commercial & industrial (C&I) loans extended by US banks, and comparable to the USD syndicated leveraged finance markets (HY bonds and leveraged loans).

Exhibit 8 performs the same comparison for Europe, with some comparable takeaways. That said, the region's increased reliance on bank lending to fund its economy, relative to the US, is clear. (Note: for purposes of this comparison, we use the available disclosure from the ECB most similar to US bank C&I lending, which is bank lending to "non-financial corporates").

For context, using the most recent data available from the Bank for International Settlements, we find that bank lending to the private non-financial sector represented 78.1% of Euro area GDP as of September 2025. This compares to 43.5% for the US, which has larger and more established private markets as well as sizable and liquid syndicated credit capital markets. We see scope for the private markets to grow further, especially outside of the US.

Exhibit 7: The size of the private credit market is not outsized relative to other corporate financing channels in North America

Amount outstanding across various lending markets in North America

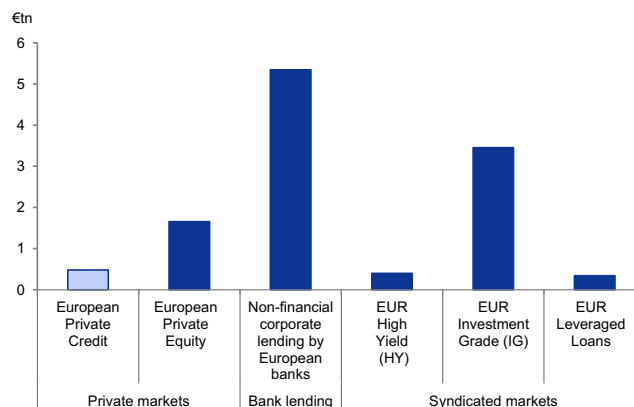


Note: North American private credit includes the BDC universe tracked by Cliffwater (as of December 2025), as well as the institutional private credit universe tracked by Preqin. Private credit and private equity figures include dry powder and are as of June 2025 (most recent as of April 2026). C&I lending includes US branches of foreign banks and is as of February 2026. USD IG, HY and Leveraged loans show index-eligible par amounts outstanding only and are as of April 2026. We exclude real estate debt and infrastructure debt from our private credit figures.

Source: Preqin, Cliffwater, Federal Reserve Board, Haver, Bloomberg, PitchBook LCD, Morningstar/LSTA

Exhibit 8: The European private credit market pales in comparison to bank lending to non-financial corporates

Amount outstanding across various lending markets in the Euro Area



Note: Private credit and private equity figures include dry powder and are as of June 2025 (most recent as of April 2026). Euro Area bank lending to non-financial corporates is as of February 2026. EUR IG, HY and Leveraged Loans show index-eligible par amounts outstanding only and are as of April 2026. We exclude real estate debt and infrastructure debt from our private credit figures.

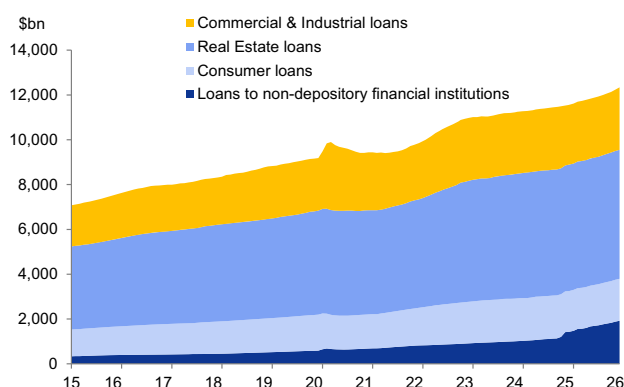
Source: Preqin, European Central Bank, Haver, Bloomberg, PitchBook LCD, Morningstar

As private credit has grown, some market participants have focused on the risk of interconnectedness with the financial system—including between private credit firms and the banks which lend to them. As shown in Exhibit 9, US banks' lending to non-depository financial institutions (NDFIs) has increased in recent years. But it is not outsized relative to other lending activities.

Furthermore, private credit firms do not represent the *entire* category of NDFIs, as illustrated in Exhibit 10. Banks with more than \$10 billion in assets are now required to disclose the various categories of their NDFI lending (a requirement that became effective in December 2024). The category of 'business credit intermediaries' includes direct lenders, private credit funds, and BDCs, among other types of funds. As of 3Q2025, FDIC data show that business credit intermediaries captured roughly 25% of the total NDFI lending. Additionally, a May 2025 analysis from the [Federal Reserve](#) showed that bank loans to private credit vehicles have higher utilization rates, higher interest rates, lower probability of default, and lower delinquency rates compared with those extended to other NDFIs.

Exhibit 9: Loans outstanding to non-depository financial institutions (NDFIs)—across all subtypes—represented 14% of total bank lending as of Feb. 2026

Loans from domestically chartered US commercial banks and the US branches of foreign banks

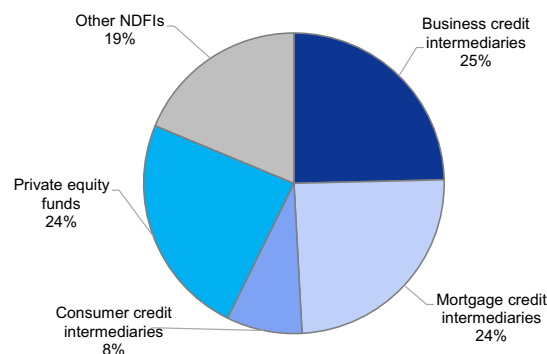


Note: Excludes “All loans not elsewhere classified”, which as of April 6, 2022, includes all other consumer loans at foreign-related institutions, previously included in line item “All other consumer loans”.

Source: Federal Reserve Board, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 10: Business credit intermediaries are viewed as a proxy for private credit firms within the broader NDFI category, and captured 25% of NDFI lending as of 3Q2025

Breakdown of NDFI lending by US banks with more than \$10 billion in assets



Note: Data are as of 3Q2025 and include only funded commitments.

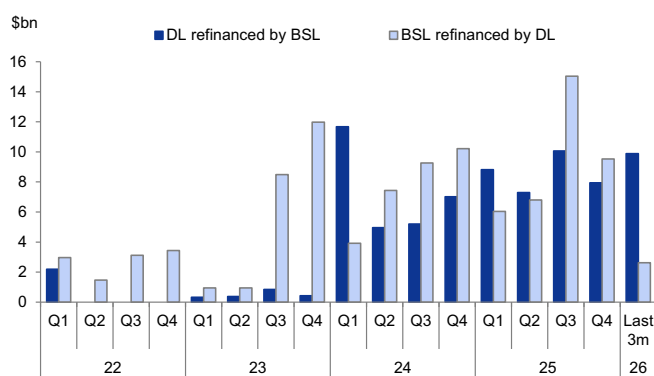
Source: FDIC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Fluidity across markets is likely here to stay

Private credit financing is no longer limited to middle market sized borrowers, as it was in the early days of the asset class. Exhibit 11 uses data from PitchBook LCD to capture two trends we view as informative: (1) direct lending deals which were ultimately refinanced by the broadly syndicated leveraged loan market, and (2) broadly syndicated leveraged loans which were refinanced by direct lending. And Exhibit 12 focuses solely on the so-called private market ‘steals,’ as tracked by KBRA’s Direct Lending Deals (DLD) database.

Exhibit 11: Issuer overlap between the leveraged loan and direct lending markets has become more visible in recent years, by tracking ‘takeout’ refinancing activity

Refinancing ‘takeouts’ between the broadly syndicated leveraged loan (BSL) and direct lending (DL) markets

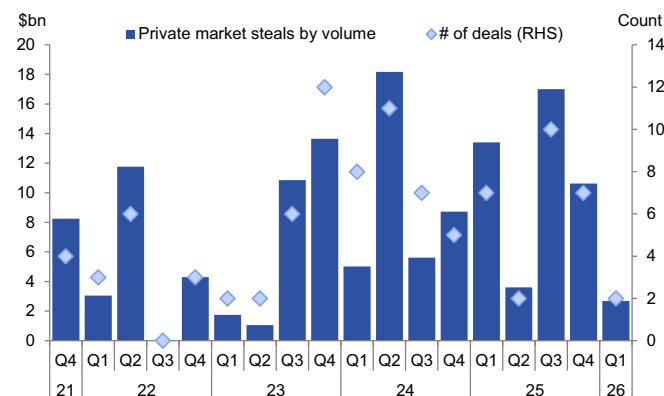


As of February 28, 2026 (most recent as of March 30, 2026).

Source: PitchBook LCD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 12: Since late 2021, there have been 97 private market ‘steals’ from the USD leveraged loan market, totaling \$139 billion in refinancing volume

Private market ‘steals’ which capture broadly syndicated leveraged loans refinanced with private credit



Note: As of February 17, 2026 (most recent as of March 30, 2026).

Source: KBRA DLD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Our takeaway? The increased fluidity across the private and syndicated credit markets—for the *same issuer*—highlights a ‘financing continuum’ in corporate credit. It also disputes the often-cited narrative that companies accessing the private credit market are doing so because they lack other options. In the early days of a company’s growth journey, a desire for financing flexibility, customization and certainty of execution may ‘tip the scales’ in favor of a private financing option. As a company grows, however, and the need for a bespoke structure may wane, the broadly syndicated loan market (or HY) may be the most appropriate avenue for financing. Either way, the markets are showing an ability and willingness to lend to an overlapping set of firms. In recent years, we have also seen instances of publicly traded firms opting to add a private financing solution as part of their overall debt capital structure.

Market volatility and technical factors may also play a role in whether a borrower chooses private or syndicated financing. For example, the buyer base of the USD leveraged loan market is uniquely concentrated given the dominance of collateralized loan obligations (CLOs). Various industry estimates suggest that CLOs account for roughly two-thirds of leveraged loan purchases in the primary market. CLO structures are rating sensitive, however, and cannot hold large amounts of CCC-rated loans (most structures have a limit of 7.5%).

During times of macroeconomic volatility, some CLOs tend to avoid purchasing loans rated B-, given concerns around downgrade risk into their limited CCC bucket allowances. This can pose a technical constraint, as 26% of the USD Leveraged Loan Index was rated B- or lower (as of March 2026), per PitchBook LCD data. As a result, borrowers in this rating range may find it difficult to obtain broadly syndicated leveraged loan financing when market conditions are choppy. They may instead turn to private credit and compensate lenders for the certainty of execution.

The growth in ‘jumbo’ private credit loans (i.e., loans sized \$1 billion or larger) in recent years (Exhibit 13) has allowed private credit lenders to service this cohort of larger borrowers—expanding the addressable market. Many of these larger borrowers could have demonstrated (or do demonstrate) access to the syndicated financing markets but choose a private credit option for a specific reason (i.e., certainty, customization, flexibility).

Exhibit 13: The growth in ‘jumbo’ private credit loans (\$1 billion or more) has allowed private credit to serve larger borrowers - many of which have historically accessed the syndicated markets

Jumbo private debt lending in the USD market: by volume and number of deals



Note: As of February 10, 2026 (most recent as of March 31, 2026).

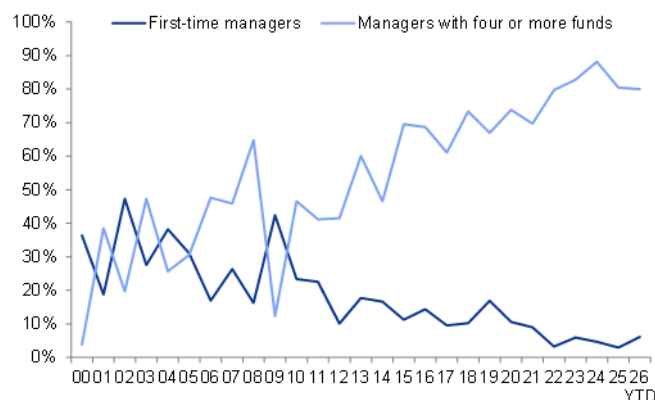
Source: KBRA DLD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The growth in jumbo private credit loans has coincided with structural shifts around private credit fundraising in recent years to favor more experienced managers with restructuring and workout expertise. As shown in Exhibit 14, managers with four or more funds outstanding have raised 83% of global fundraising in closed-end funds (tracked by Preqin), on average, from 2022 to 2025. First-time managers, by contrast, have raised 4% during that time.

These larger shares of the fundraising ‘pie’ have translated into growing private credit fund sizes. Data from Preqin show the average private credit fund size was over \$1 billion in each of 2024 and 2025 compared to average fund sizes of \$550 million in 2019 and \$539 million in 2018. Additionally, several funds in the \$10 billion-plus range have been raised over the past few years (again, as tracked by Preqin). Our colleagues in European equity research have previously flagged the merits of consolidation in the alternative asset manager universe given the importance of scale.

Exhibit 14: From 2022 to 2025, managers with four or more funds have, on average, generated 83% of total global private debt fundraising

Global private debt fundraising by manager experience

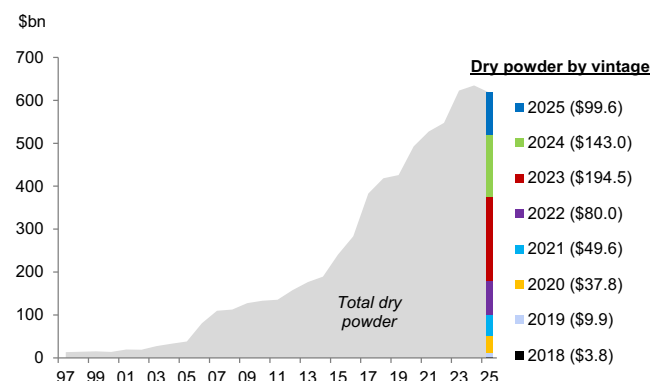


Note: As of March 30, 2026.

Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 15: Dry powder in private debt funds was elevated as of mid-2025, and is expected to moderate in 2026 with deployment

Global private debt dry powder by vintage year



Note: As of June 30, 2025 (most recent available as of March 30, 2026, due to reporting lags from GPs and LPs).

Source: PitchBook LCD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Placing performance in perspective

A common question we often receive is how private credit performance has compared to the syndicated markets. To do this, we turn to the Cliffwater Direct Lending Index (CDLI), which is an asset-weighted index of over 21,000 directly originated, US middle market loan holdings totaling \$549 billion as of December 31, 2025 (most recent available).

We use the CDLI, which was launched in 2015 and reconstructed back to September 2004 using publicly available quarterly SEC filings, as a proxy for the US direct lending market. According to data tracked by Preqin, North America is the largest regional concentration in the global private credit market, and direct lending is the largest of the strategies (others include distressed, mezzanine, and special situations).

As Exhibit 16 shows, total returns for the CDLI have outpaced both the USD HY bond and leveraged loan indices in 15 of the last 21 years. And CDLI total returns have been positive in all but one of those years (2008, which was -6.5%).

Exhibit 16: Total returns for the CDLI have outpaced the USD high yield and leveraged loan indices in 15 of the last 21 years

Calendar year total return comparison; green = best performer, red = worst performer

Year	Cliffwater Direct Lending (CDLI)	USD HY	USD Leveraged Loans
2005	10.1%	2.7%	5.1%
2006	13.7%	11.9%	6.8%
2007	10.2%	1.9%	2.0%
2008	-6.5%	-26.2%	-29.1%
2009	13.2%	58.2%	51.6%
2010	15.8%	15.1%	10.1%
2011	9.8%	5.0%	1.5%
2012	14.0%	15.8%	9.7%
2013	12.7%	7.4%	5.3%
2014	9.6%	2.5%	1.6%
2015	5.5%	-4.5%	-0.7%
2016	11.2%	17.1%	10.2%
2017	8.6%	7.5%	4.1%
2018	8.1%	-2.1%	0.4%
2019	9.0%	14.3%	8.6%
2020	5.5%	7.1%	3.1%
2021	12.8%	5.3%	5.2%
2022	6.3%	-11.2%	-0.8%
2023	12.1%	13.5%	13.3%
2024	11.3%	8.2%	9.0%
2025	9.3%	8.6%	5.9%

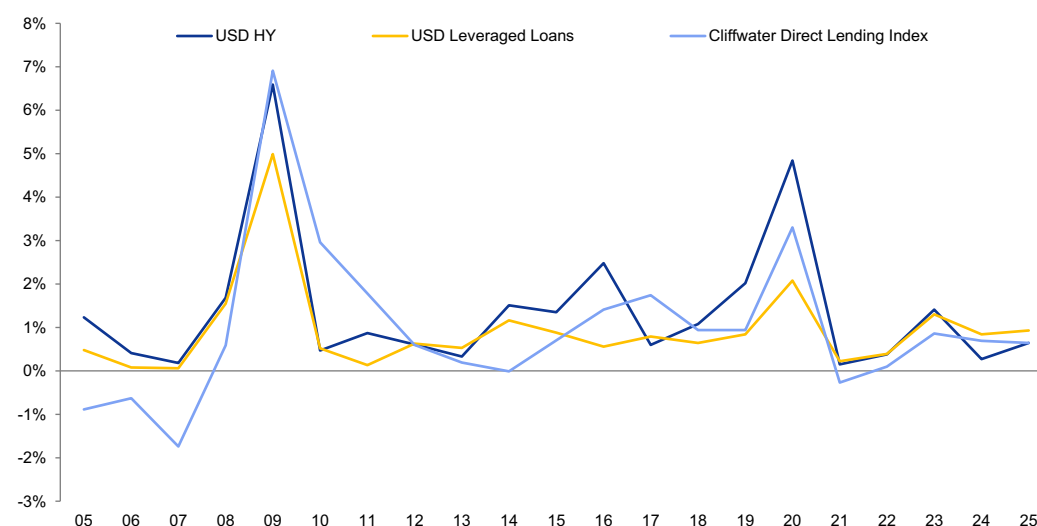
Note: Captures annual data through December 31, 2025.

Source: Cliffwater Direct Lending Index, Bloomberg, PitchBook LCD, Morningstar LSTA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

For the full-year 2025, realized losses for the CDLI were 64bp: a level below the longer-term (since inception) historical average of 100bp (Exhibit 17). For context, for the three years surrounding the global financial crisis (2008 through 2010), the *cumulative* realized loss for the CDLI was -10.16%. Additionally, in that 2008 through 2010 period, the CDLI included more junior lending structures compared to today (where 87% of the loans in the index are senior).

Exhibit 17: Realized losses for the CDLI have generally tracked the public credit markets, albeit with some variation depending on sector drivers

Annual realized losses (gains) for the Cliffwater Direct Lending Index vs. the USD HY and Leveraged Loan indices



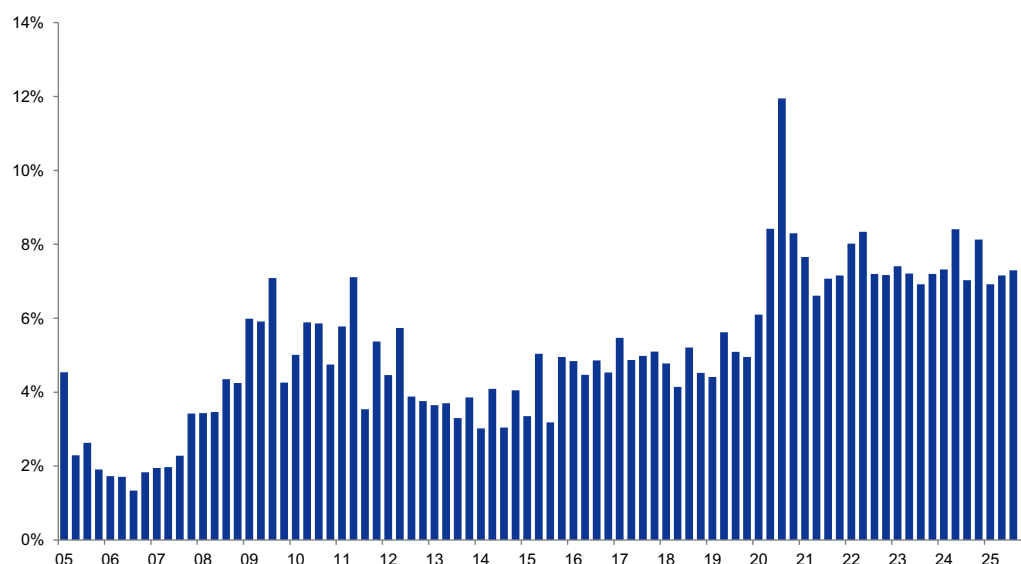
Note: Captures annual data through December 31, 2025. For the CDLI: realized gains in prior periods were largely driven by equity stubs and warrants attached to direct loans, particularly in second lien and mezzanine loans which were a greater fraction of the CDLI prior to 2008.

Source: Cliffwater Direct Lending Index, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

While we view total returns and realized losses as the most important (and related) performance indicators, we also track metrics related to payment-in-kind (PIK) and non-accrual activity for *directional* indicators on the health of the private credit market. Starting with PIK—which is closely linked to financial stress of a borrower, especially when added *after* origination of a loan—we find a largely range-bound picture over the past few years. Using the CDLI, PIK activity has represented, on average, 7.4% of total income since 3Q2021. And as of December 31, 2025, this metric was *below* the 8%+ levels seen at various points over the past few years (Exhibit 18). As of 4Q2025, the average mark on funded PIK term loans in the CDLI was \$91.05.

Exhibit 18: PIK activity within the CDLI has been range bound in recent years and is not signaling a sharp deterioration

Payment-in-kind as a share of total income for the Cliffwater Direct Lending Index



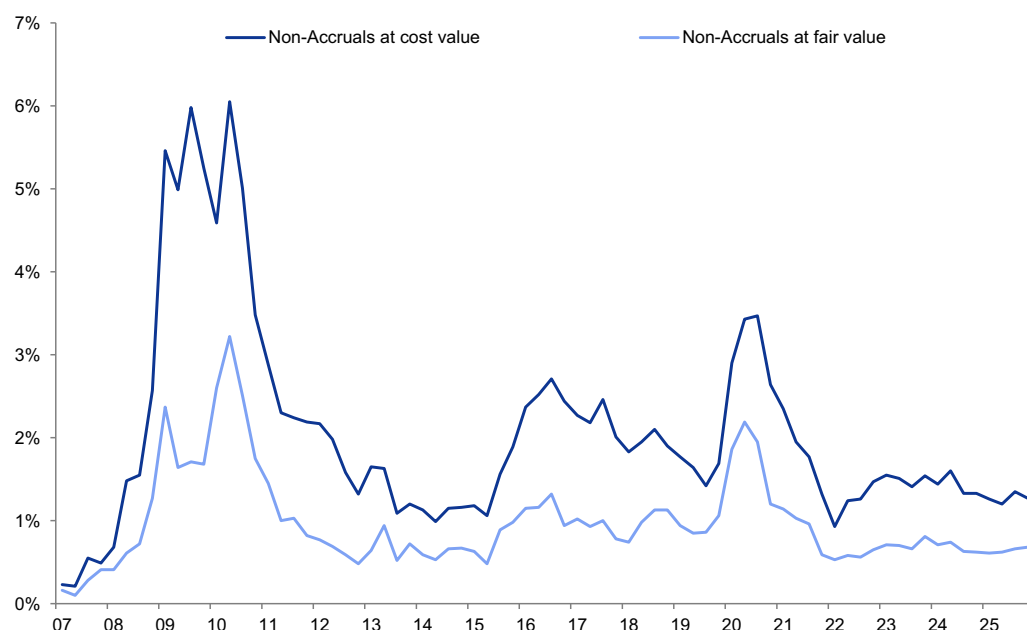
Note: Captures data through December 31, 2025.

Source: Cliffwater Direct Lending Index, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Our review of non-accrual trends for the CDLI reveals a similar ‘range bound’ pattern, as highlighted in Exhibit 19. A granular subset of the data shows that 44% of 2025’s non-accrual activity was driven by the 2021 and 2022 vintages. These vintages (especially 2021 and *early* 2022) were formed in the ultra-low interest rate environment which prevailed immediately following the onset of the 2020 pandemic.

Exhibit 19: Non-accrual rates showed a similar ‘range bound’ pattern through year-end 2025

Non-accrual rates for the Cliffwater Direct Lending Index



Note: Captures data through December 31, 2025.

Source: Cliffwater Direct Lending Index, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

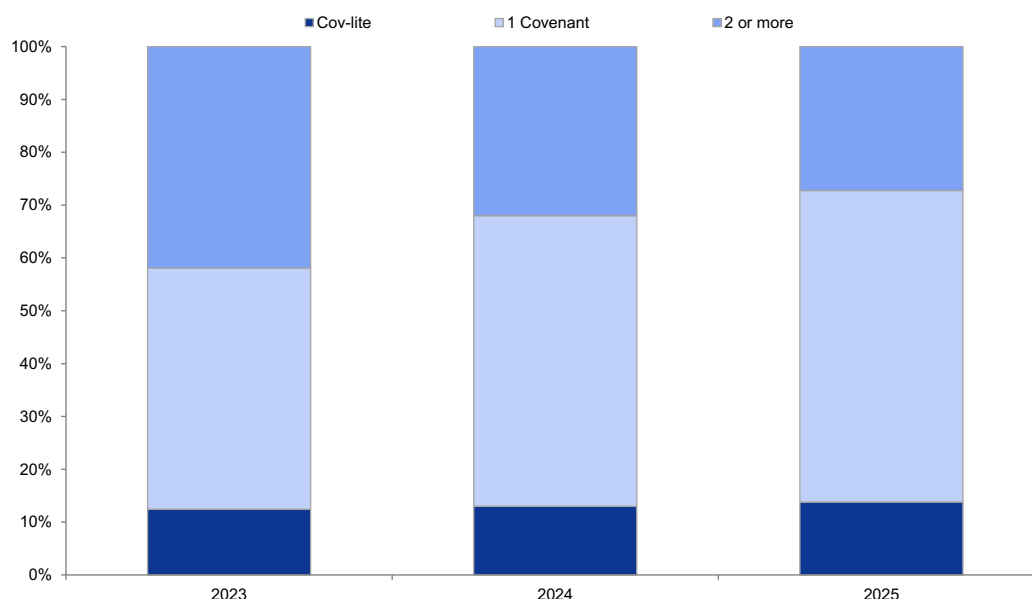
Pricing and terms—some accommodation by lenders, but still largely intact

Another frequent question from market participants—beyond private credit’s *role* in funding markets—relates to how terms and conditions have evolved. To analyze this, we utilize the KBRA Direct Lending Deals database, which tracks deals from more than 2,000 private equity sponsors across the US and Europe.

As shown in Exhibit 20, the share of deals in the US direct lending market with two covenants decreased in 2025 (27%) relative to 2023 (42%), in favor of more ‘one covenant’ deals (59% in 2025 vs. 46% in 2023). The share of so-called ‘cov-lite’ deals, which lack traditional financial maintenance covenants, also increased slightly in 2025 (14%) relative to 2023 (12%). We believe this was driven, in large part, by the receptive market tone which prevailed in the syndicated credit markets for much of 2024 and 2025. During this time, the leveraged loan and high yield bond markets were open to serve a wide range of borrowers across the quality spectrum.

Exhibit 20: Cov-lite deals represented 14% of US direct lending deals in 2025—a slight increase vs. 2024

Covenants per deal in the US direct lending market



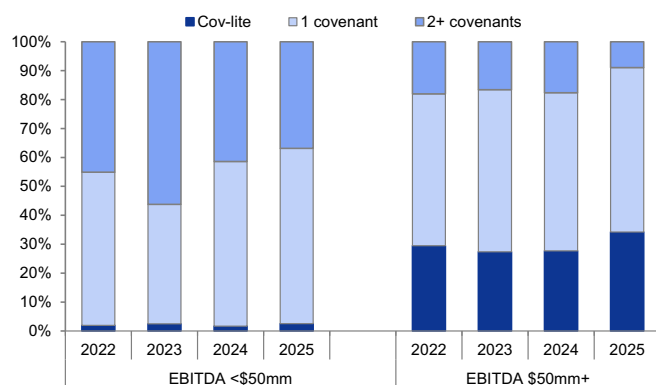
Note: Captures data through year-end 2025.

Source: KBRA DLD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 21 supports this view by splitting the cov-lite deals by company size. Indeed, companies with a larger annual EBITDA base (\$50 million or larger) were more likely to have cov-lite deals. By contrast, firms with a smaller EBITDA base (less than \$50 million) were much less likely to have a cov-lite structure. More importantly, in our view: across both size cohorts in private credit, covenants were still more likely to be present than not. This compares to the USD Leveraged Loan Index, where 92% of the loans outstanding are cov-lite (Exhibit 22).

Exhibit 21: Cov-lite deals are less common among smaller borrowers, relative to firms with larger EBITDA bases

Covenants per deal, by company annual EBITDA, in the US direct lending market

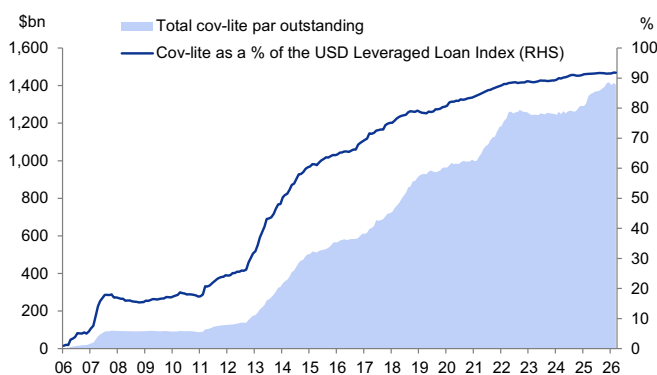


Note: Captures data through year-end 2025.

Source: KBRA DLD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 22: 92% of the USD Leveraged Loan Index was cov-lite as of March 2026

Cov-lite par amount outstanding and the share of the USD Leveraged loan index that is Cov-lite



Note: As of March 31, 2026.

Source: PitchBook LCD, Morningstar / LSTA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

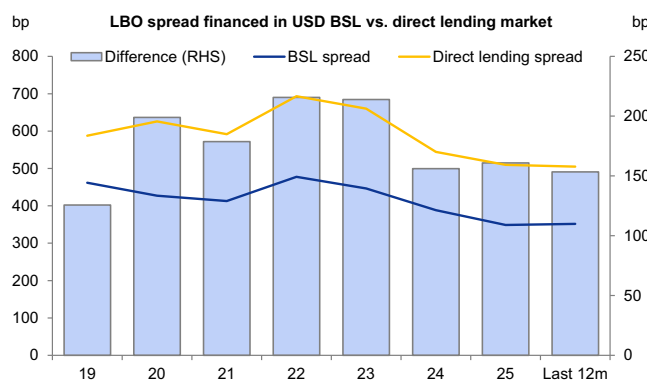
Importantly, this covenant dynamic leads to a different definition of ‘default’ between the private credit and public credit asset classes and is a key reason why we do not directly compare default activity between the two markets. For example, because private credit loans tend to have more maintenance covenants (relative to the broadly syndicated leveraged loan market), *covenant* defaults are often the first sign of ‘default’ in the private credit market and are captured in the default statistics. By contrast, in the syndicated leveraged loan market, the first sign of ‘default’ is more likely to be a distressed exchange or a missed coupon or principal payment (because there are not as many covenants on which to default in the first place).

As a result, ‘defaults’ in private credit do not always automatically translate into monetary losses. Often, tripping a covenant can be a way for a lender to bring the borrower ‘back to the table’ to renegotiate terms (requiring an equity contribution from a private equity sponsor, for example). For this reason, we place more emphasis on *realized losses* in private credit (again, Exhibit 17)—especially when conducting comparisons vs. the syndicated credit market.

As for pricing, relative to the peaks in 2022 and 2023, spreads for new leveraged buyouts (LBOs) financed in the private and syndicated credit markets have compressed over the course of 2024 and 2025 (Exhibits 23 and 24). But a notable spread differential between direct lending and the broadly syndicated leveraged loan market has persisted in both the US and Europe. This differential, in our view, exists in large part to compensate the private credit lender for holding the loan until maturity (or until another event, such as a company sale or refinancing), as well as for the ‘value’ of customization, flexibility, and certainty of execution and pricing.

Exhibit 23: The spread differential between USD leveraged loans and direct lending averaged 158bp in 2024-2025, vs. 215bp in 2022-2023

Spread of leveraged buyouts financed in the USD direct lending market vs. the broadly syndicated leveraged loan market

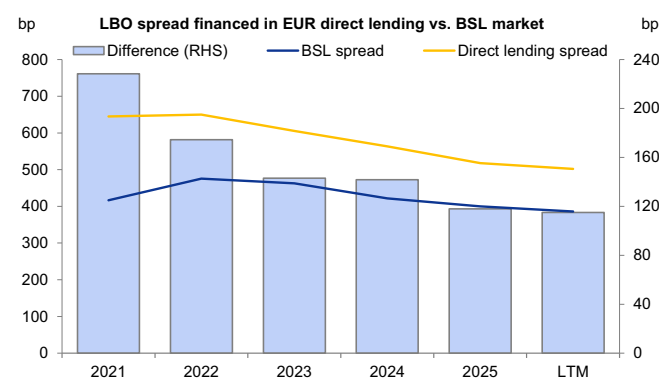


Note: Data through February 28, 2026 (most recent available as of March 30, 2026). Direct lending spread data reflects senior secured first-lien loans and unitranche facilities. BSL data reflects loans issued to all leveraged borrowers.

Source: PitchBook LCD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 24: Some spread compression is also visible in the EUR market

Spread of leveraged buyouts financed in the EUR direct lending market vs. the broadly syndicated leveraged loan market



Note: Data through February 28, 2026 (most recent available as of March 30, 2026). Direct lending spread data reflects senior secured first-lien loans and unitranche facilities. BSL data reflects loans issued to all leveraged borrowers.

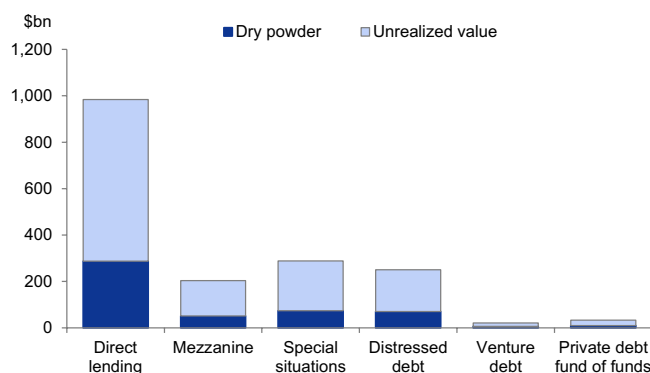
Source: PitchBook LCD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The case for a broadening—across strategies—in fundraising

Much of the AUM in the ‘traditional’ private credit universe resides within the strategy of direct lending (Exhibit 25). But as Exhibit 26 shows, strategies across distressed, special situations and mezzanine have ebbed and flowed with market conditions—often growing their share of overall fundraising during periods of market dislocations. We see scope for these adjacent strategies to increase their share of fundraising in the coming years, closer to the longer-term historical pattern.

Exhibit 25: Direct lending represents the majority of institutional private credit AUM

Global private credit assets under management, by strategy

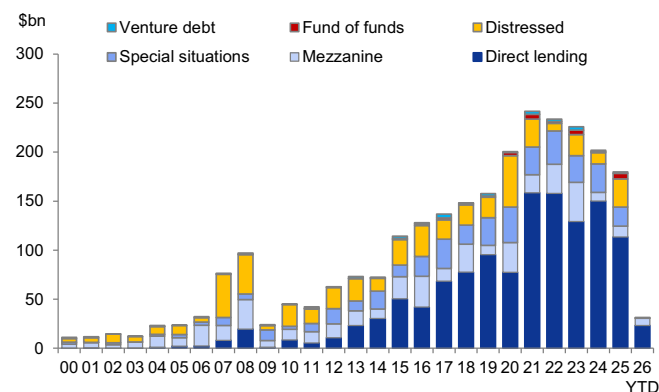


Note: Captures the Preqin universe of closed-end funds and excludes BDCs. As of June 2025 (most recent available due to reporting lags).

Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 26: We see scope for fundraising in special situations and opportunistic strategies to accelerate if sustained dislocations materialize in the syndicated credit markets

Historical private debt fundraising, by strategy



Note: Captures the Preqin universe of closed-end funds and excludes BDCs. As of April 7, 2026.

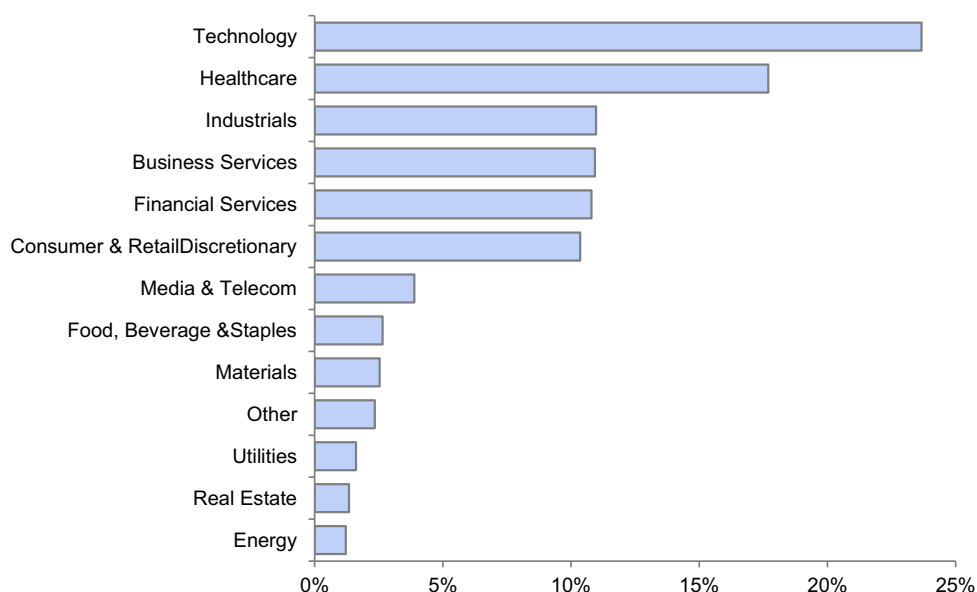
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The growth backdrop is one of the key signposts to watch, in our view, as a ‘solid enough’ macroeconomic backdrop is likely to validate the low realized losses seen in the asset class so far (discussed above). Furthermore, while many market participants are focused on the potential for artificial intelligence-related disruption in the Software sector, it is important to note that private credit is not unique in its large weighting towards this industry.

As Exhibits 27 and 28 show, both the private credit *and* the broadly syndicated leveraged loan markets have large sector weights to Technology and Software. In our view, and given these sector weights: if a near-term, broad-based AI-related disruption materializes in the private credit market, the broadly syndicated leveraged loan market is highly likely to be affected as well. And in that instance, private credit may utilize its dry powder (again, Exhibit 15) to fill financing voids left by market volatility.

Exhibit 27: While Technology is the largest weight in the US direct lending market...

Industry composition of the Cliffwater Direct Lending Index, as of year-end 2025

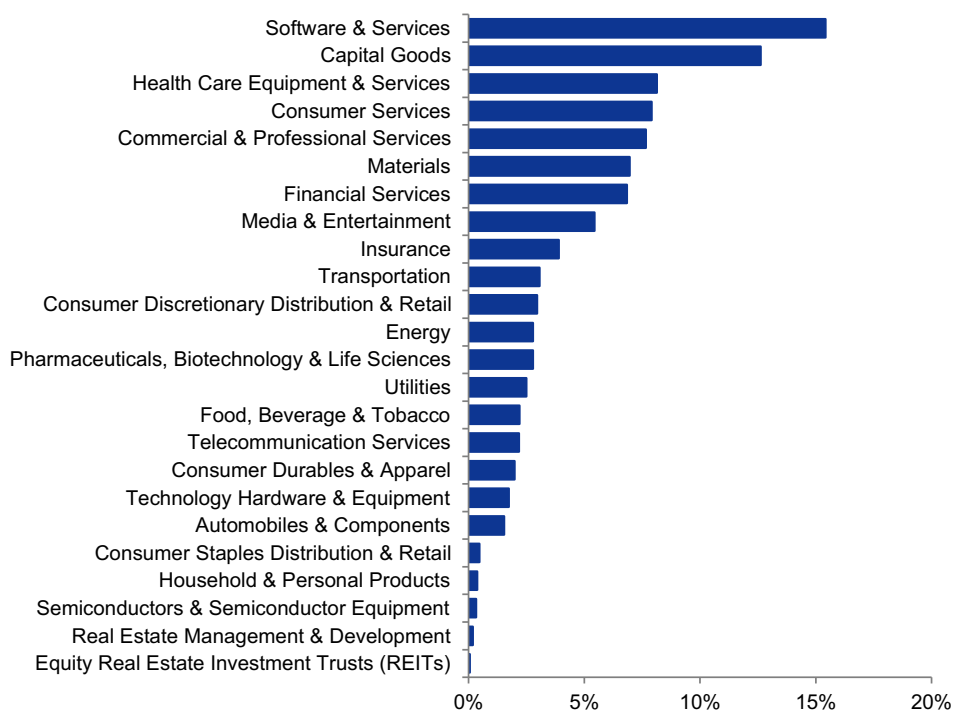


Note: As of December 31, 2025 (most recent).

Source: Cliffwater, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 28: ...the broadly syndicated loan market also has large exposure

Industry composition of the USD Leveraged loan index



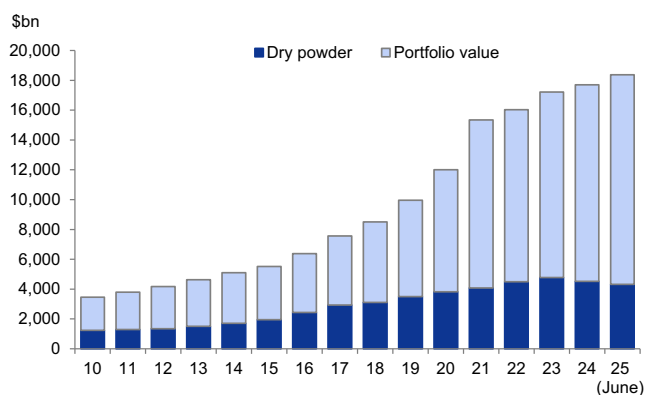
Note: As of March 2026 (most recent).

Source: PitchBook LCD, Morningstar/LSTA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Private markets: AUM and growth

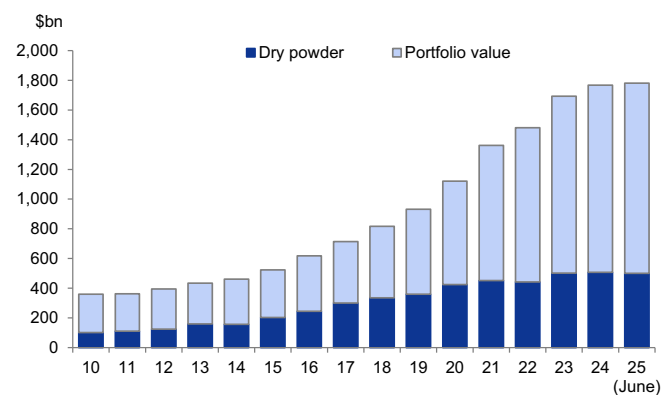
Exhibit 29: Total AUM for all private funds

The AUM figure includes private equity, private debt, real estate, infrastructure, and natural resources funds



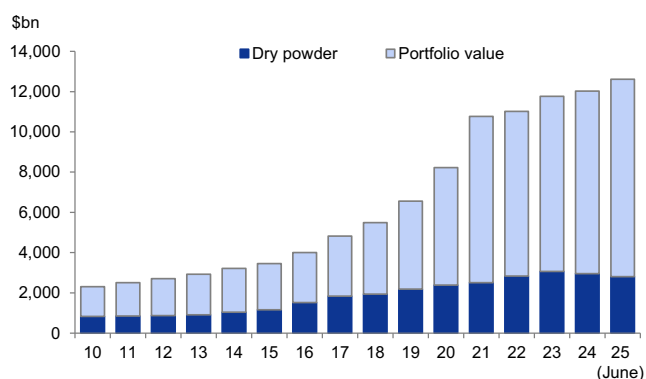
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 30: Total AUM for private debt funds



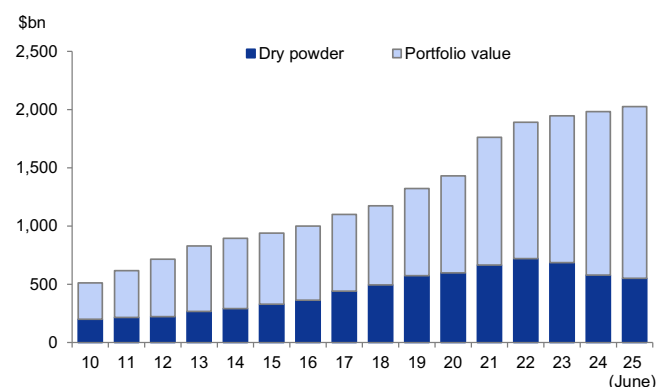
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 31: Total AUM for private equity funds



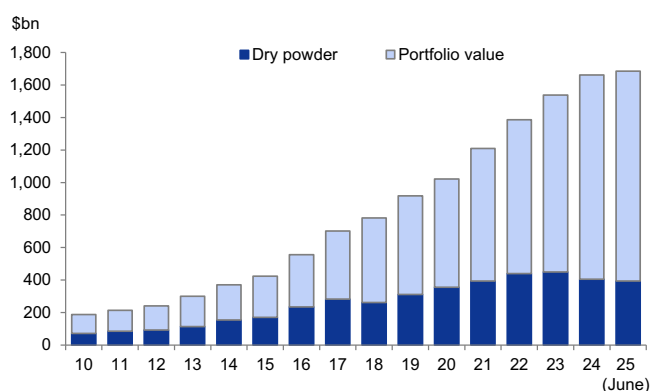
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 32: Total AUM for private real estate funds



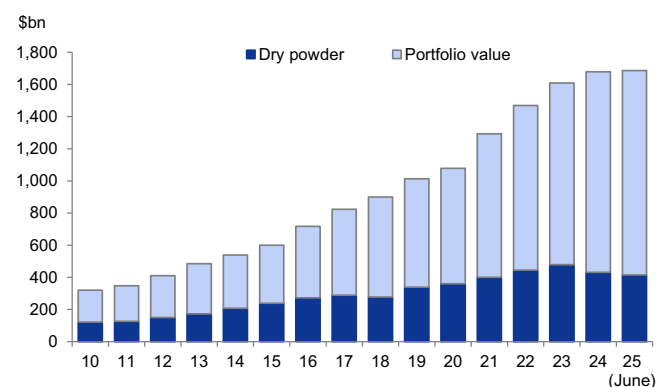
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 33: Total AUM for private infrastructure funds



Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

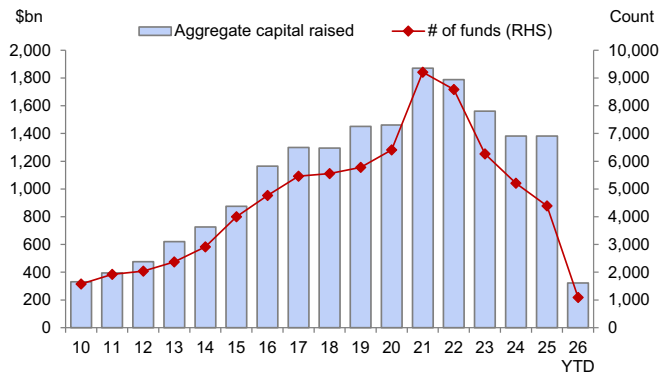
Exhibit 34: Total AUM for private natural resources funds



Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

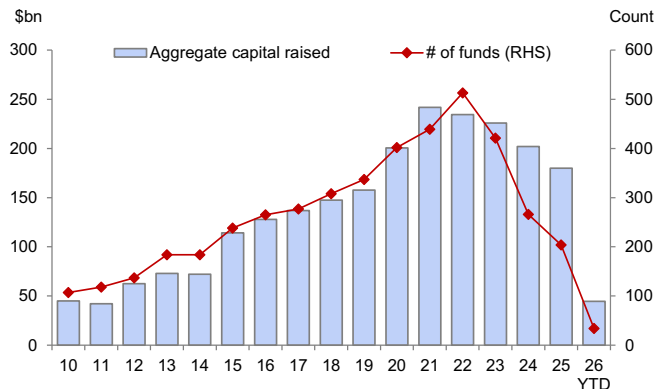
Fundraising activity in private markets

Exhibit 35: Total fundraising for all private funds



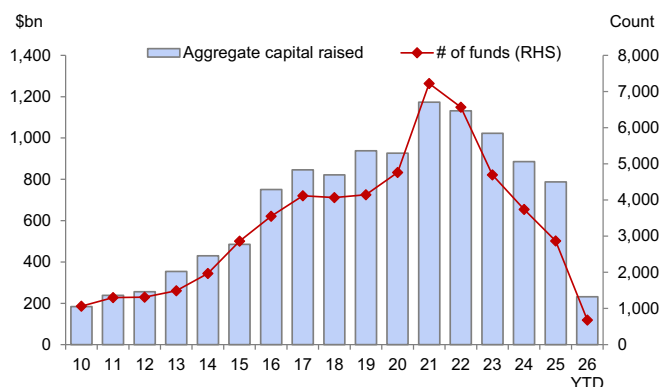
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 36: Total fundraising for all private debt funds



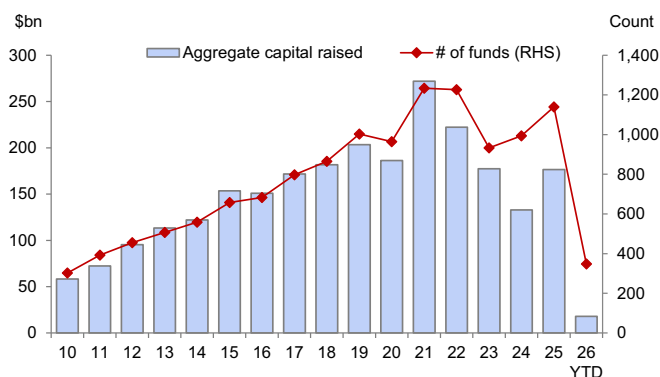
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 37: Total fundraising for all private equity funds



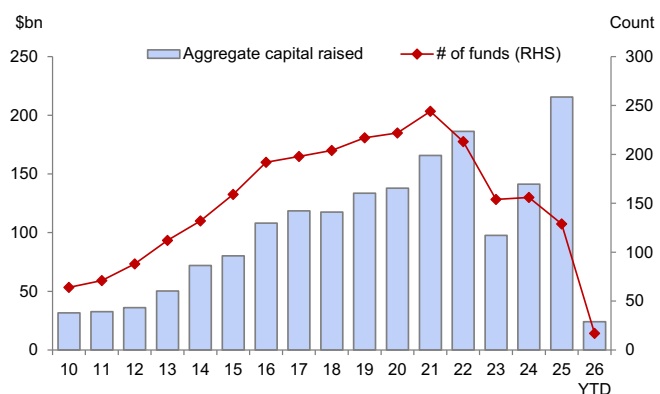
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 38: Total fundraising for all private real estate funds



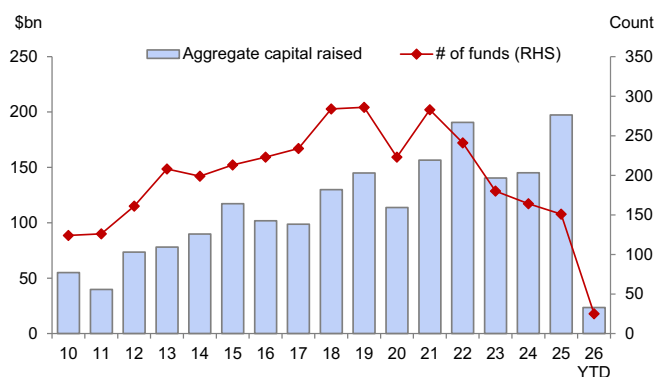
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 39: Total fundraising for all private infrastructure funds



Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

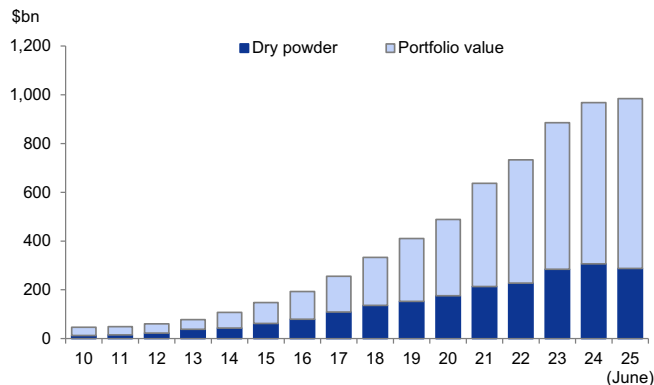
Exhibit 40: Total fundraising for all private natural resource funds



Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

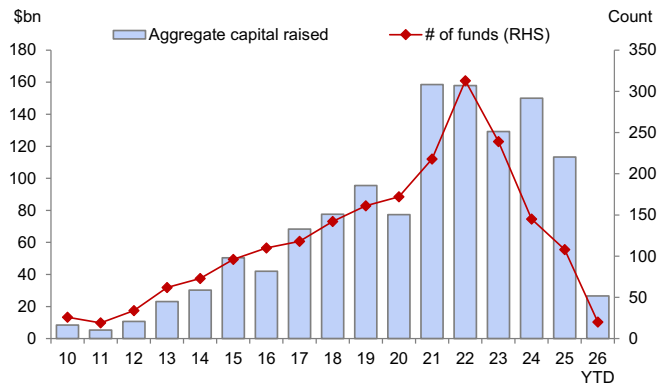
Private debt strategies: AUM and fundraising

Exhibit 41: Total AUM for direct lending funds



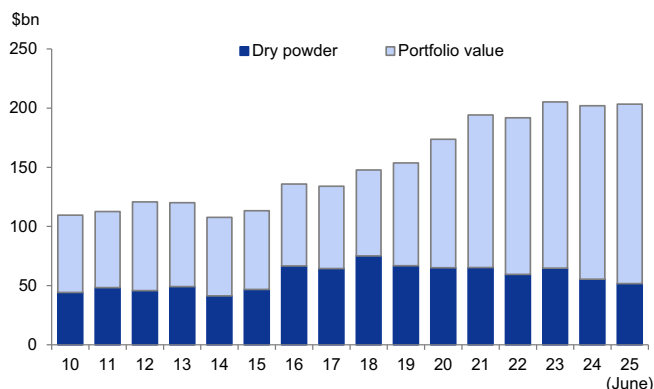
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 42: Total fundraising for direct lending funds



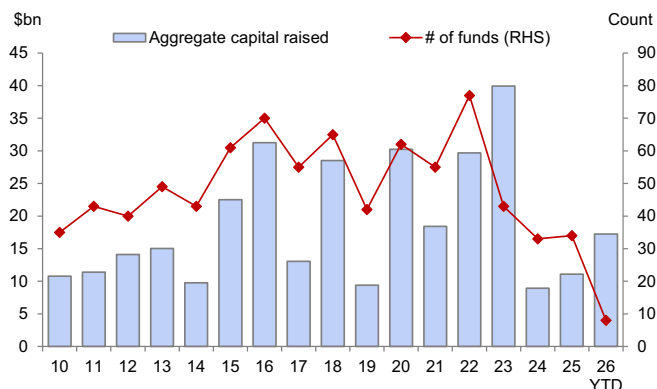
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 43: Total AUM for mezzanine funds



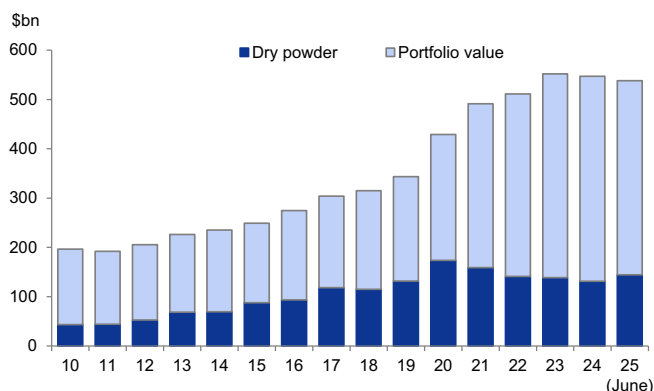
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 44: Total fundraising for mezzanine funds



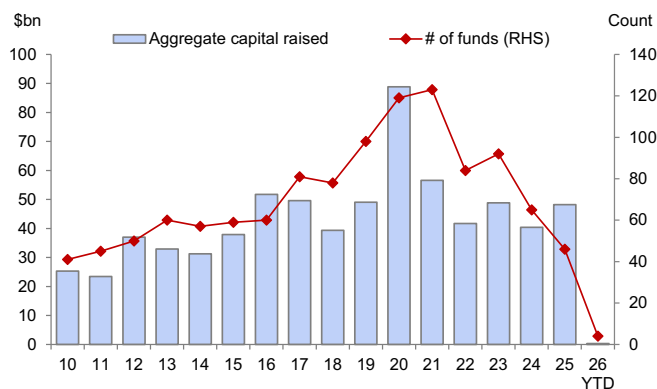
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 45: Total AUM for distressed debt and special situation funds



Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 46: Total fundraising for distressed debt and special situation funds

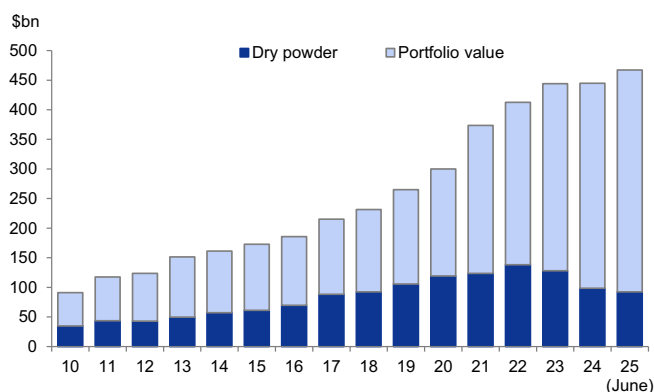


Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Private real estate strategies: AUM and fundraising

Exhibit 47: Total AUM for core and core plus funds

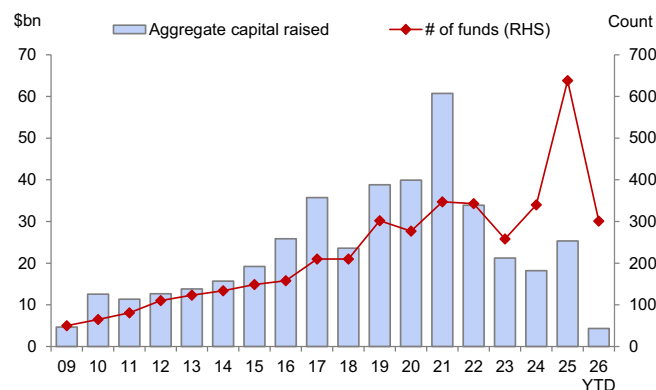
The AUM figure includes real estate core and core plus funds



Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

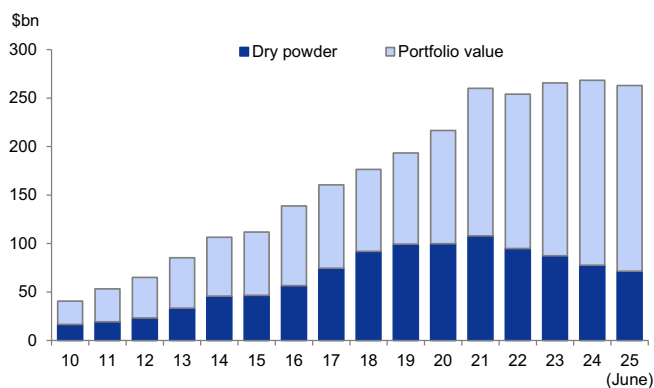
Exhibit 48: Total fundraising for core funds

The fundraising figure includes real estate core and core plus funds



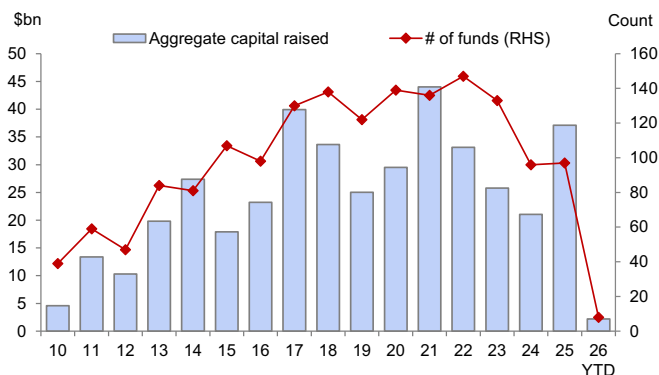
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 49: Total AUM for real estate debt funds



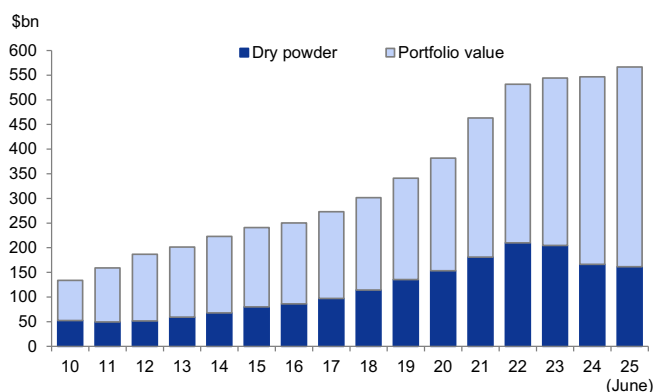
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 50: Total fundraising for real estate debt funds



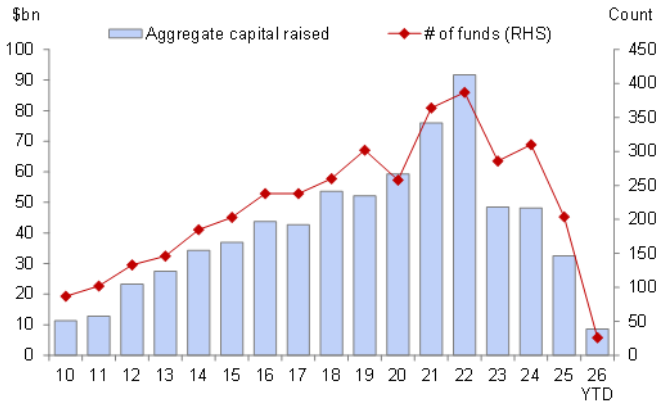
Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 51: Total AUM for value-added funds



Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 52: Total fundraising for value-added funds

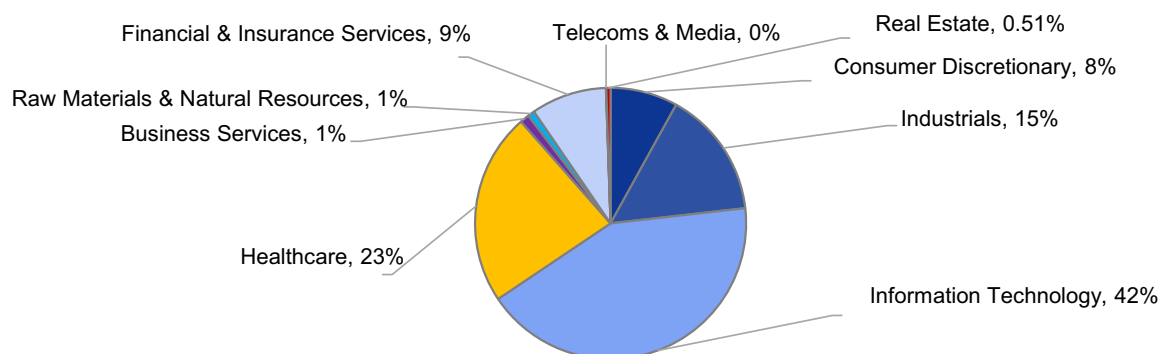


Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Fundraising in private debt markets by sector, region and investor base

Exhibit 53: Sector breakdown

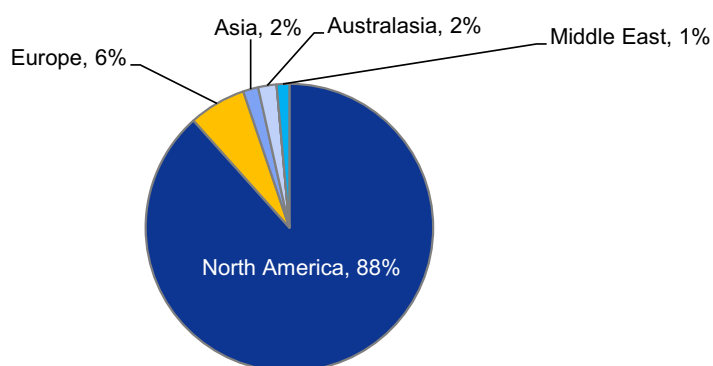
From 1/1/2025 to 12/31/2025



Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 54: Region breakdown

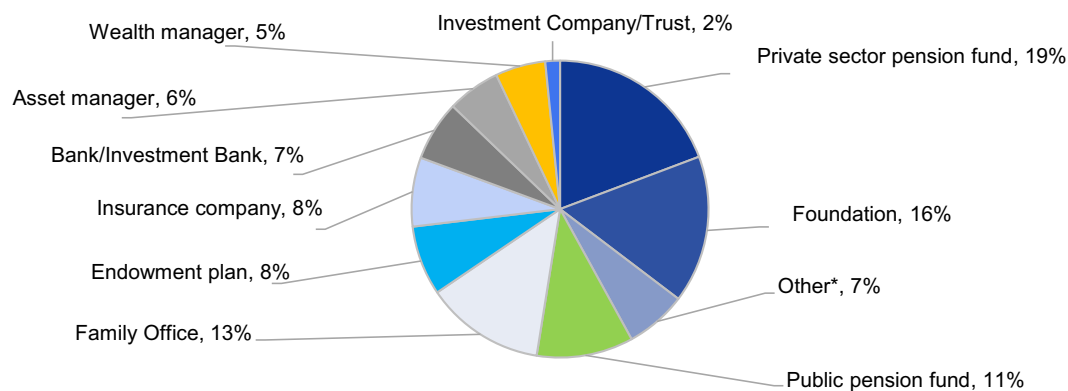
From 1/1/2025 to 12/31/2025



Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 55: Investor base breakdown

As of 2/2026



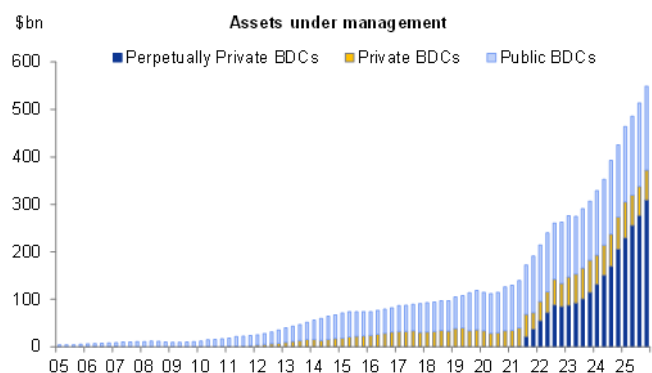
Note: Other includes Sovereign Wealth Funds, Government Agencies, Corporate Investors, Superannuation Scheme Investors

Source: Preqin, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Key AUM, pricing and yield trends in private lending markets

Exhibit 56: AUM breakdown of the business development company (BDC) universe

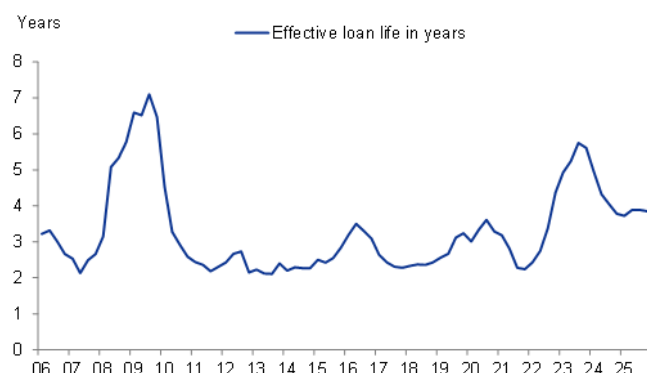
As of 12/31/2025



Source: Cliffwater, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 57: Effective loan life of the Cliffwater Direct Lending Index (CDLI), in years

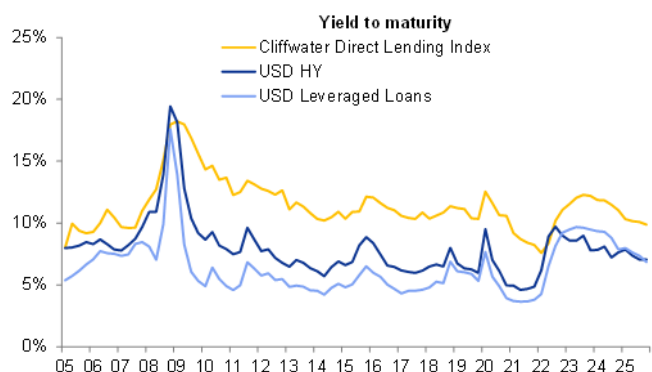
As of 12/31/2025



Source: Cliffwater, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 58: Yield comparison between the CDLI and the USD HY and Leveraged Loan indices

As of 12/31/2025

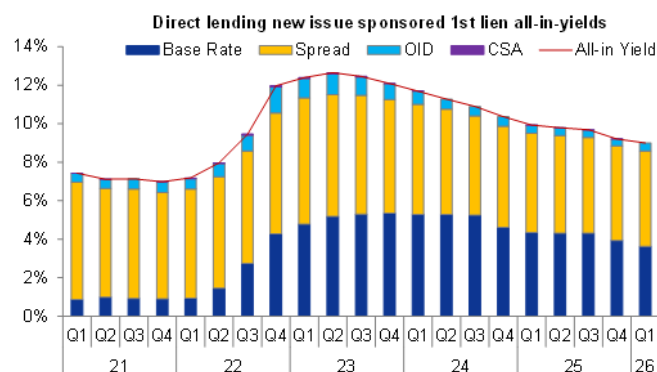


Note: CDLI uses a 3-year takeout yield. Performance data represents past performance, which does not guarantee future results. There is no assurance that similar investments will be made or that similar results will be achieved.

Source: Bloomberg, Cliffwater, PitchBook LCD, Morningstar/LSTA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 59: Quarterly sponsored 1st lien all-in-yields for new issues tracked by Cliffwater

As of 3/20/2026

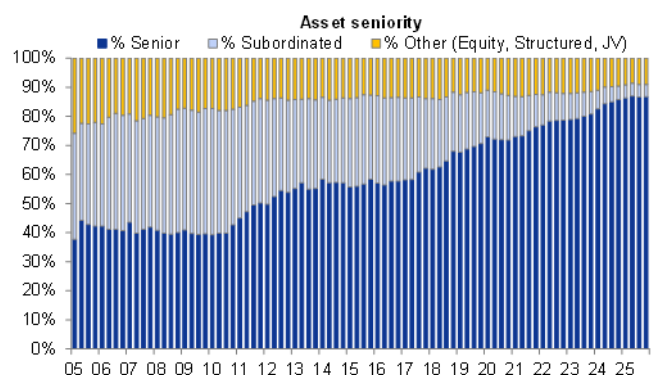


Note: OID is amortized based on a 3-year term to repayment.

Source: Cliffwater, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 60: Historical distribution of loan asset seniority in the CDLI

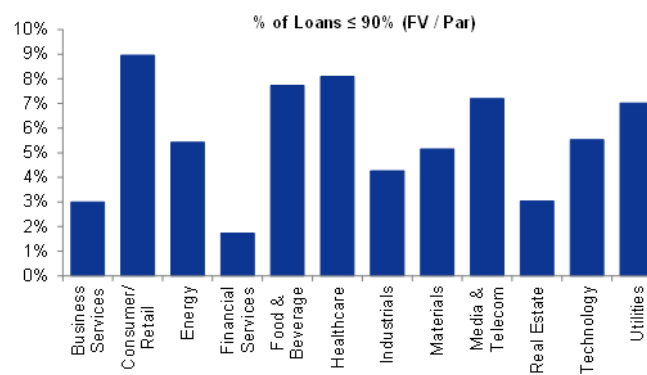
As of 12/31/2025



Source: Cliffwater, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 61: Sector distribution of the share of CDLI loans marked at 90% of par, or less

As of 12/31/2025



Note: Sum of \$ at cost.

Source: Cliffwater, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

We, Amanda Lynam, CPA, Arun Manohar, Spencer Rogers, CFA, Sara Grut, Shamshad Ali, Ben Shumway and Neth Karunamuni, hereby certify that all of the views expressed in this report accurately reflect our personal views, which have not been influenced by considerations of the firm's business or client relationships.

Unless otherwise stated, the individuals listed on the cover page of this report are analysts in Goldman Sachs' Global Investment Research division.

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